mid-1990s. Since those days, this small industrial town in Rajasthan had prospered from the side hustle that almost became its identity. Till the bad news started piling up: a spurt in student suicides accelerating the longer-term trend of India's coaching industry getting geographically more decentralised.

LOSING ITS USP

National expansion has softened the hit for large firms, like Allen Career Institute, which too has its uptake halving since 2022. "The narrative around Kota's contribution is being lost," says a coaching owner. Naveen Maheshwari, director, Allen, sees dummy schools as a symptom, not the disease. After Plus-2 shifted to schools in the 1990s, CBSE-affiliated schools of uneven quality mushroomed in Rajasthan. Coaching centres filled the gap, he says, with dummy schools as a workaround for poor students. Point is, Rajasthan risks losing its edge. States like Maharashtra, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have a structural advantage with their junior college system. Whether independent, owned by coaching centres or attached to schools, they allow seamless integration of state board curricula and elite coaching. Students take school and coaching classes in the same building, with state policies aiding this. "They are aligned to exam realities," says Maheshwari. As major players explore those greener pastures, Rajasthan may have to move fast if it wishes to save a small-town haven that once broke the dominance of the South in entrance exams. ■

Takeaways

- **A Lok Sabha committee, a central panel and a state SIT are probing the Kota model**
- **Rajasthan may lose edge against southern dominance in entrance exam coaching**

▶ MAHARASHTRA

Congress Wants to Dance Solo

The Thackeray reunion and Uddhav's wider cachet goads the GOP into junking the Aghadi for BMC poll

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

THE MAHA VIKAS AGHADI (MVA) was looking a bit more like an 'aghadi'—a united front—with the Thackeray cousins close to formally ending a two-decade-long estrangement. That would have been just the emotional tonic the MVA needed ahead of crucial civic polls. But what's an Opposition front without a bit of drama and attitude? That comes courtesy the Congress. Apparently, the Grand Old Party has second thoughts on going with the alliance for the Mumbai chapter of the polls, due early next year. So the heated contest for the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) will see more dust being kicked up than anticipated. As it is, the ruling Mahayuti and the MVA are both uneasy triangles in themselves. The Congress will now be a runaway hypotenuse.

The decision stems from a fear of losing its core voters. In its view, this can happen along a few contradictory axes. First, the softer image of Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Uddhav Thackeray, especially after he joined anti-BJP politics in 2019, has translated into a new acceptability for his party



THREE'S COMPANY From left, Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Uddhav Thackeray, MNS chief Raj Thackeray and state Congress chief Harshwardhan Sapkal